Writing footnotes to explain certainty of evidence judgments

Explanatory footnotes should make the rationale for assessments of certainty of evidence transparent. They may also specify the source of the baseline risk used to calculate absolute effects. Explanatory footnotes should be brief, ideally no longer than two printed lines; provide appropriate information about reasons for judgments, additional information considered, and interpretation of results; created for the specific target audience; and be clear and self-explanatory.

The following examples provide suboptimal explanations, explain why these are not appropriate, and provide a better alternative:

For rating down for imprecision: *“Although the confidence interval does not cross the null, the confidence intervals were wide”*

Problems: does not clearly and explicitly justify rating down or not; not sufficiently explicit in that the term “wide” can mean different things depending on the thresholds set); and does not follow GRADE guidance for addressing imprecision.
A better explanation: “Although the 95% confidence interval does not cross the threshold of interest (null value), the point estimate suggests a large benefit and the body of evidence does not meet the optimal information size”

For rating down for inconsistency: “*I^2>30%, p value <0.1*”

Problems: This explanation is not informative (does not clearly and explicitly justify rating down, “>30%” can take many different values), relevant (many users may not be able to infer what this means), or accurate (does not seem to follow GRADE guidance for addressing inconsistency appropriately- As described in detail in Article 3 addressing inconsistency, GRADE users should never use the I^2 alone as the basis for rating down for inconsistency. Further, we do not recommend use of the p-value for the test of heterogeneity in Core GRADE (it adds little to the I^2 and is more difficult to interpret).
A better explanation: “Point estimates suggest large and important differences in effect, not all confidence intervals overlap, and I^2 is relatively high (59%). Subgroup analysis did not explain this inconsistency.”

As a justification for not rating down for risk of bias: *“Three of the studies had high risk of bias due to inappropriate randomization, five had unclear risk of bias due to missing outcome data, three had high risk of bias in the outcome measurement, and one had high risk of bias due to selection of the reported result”*

Problems: this could be summarized appropriately without losing information; it is unclear why this led to rating down, as the authors have not specified what weight in the pooled estimate the three studies had and does not follow GRADE guidance for assessing risk of bias.
A better explanation: “Five of the studies, accounting for 32% of the weight of the pooled estimate, had high risk of bias in at least one domain, but their results were not importantly different than the results of the studies at low risk of bias and therefore we did not rate down”.